

Arlington Stories — Administrator's Guide

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Adding an Oral History to Arlington Stories

This guide is for staff and volunteers who manage the archive. It covers the complete workflow for adding one interview, from gathering the files to checking the finished page.

The field names below come from this project's **Oral History Interview** resource template. For general help with the Omeka interface, see the official documentation for [items](#), [media](#), and [item sets](#).

Before using this guide: an administrator must have installed the custom Oral History vocabulary and created the **Oral History Interview** resource template. If that template is missing, stop and ask an administrator to follow the [project setup instructions](#).

Before you start: gather your materials

It's much easier if you have everything in one place before you begin. For each interview, collect:

- ☐ **The audio (or video) recording** — an .mp3, .m4a, or .mp4 file works.
- ☐ **The transcript** — a typed version of what was said. You will paste plain text into Omeka, even if the working copy is a Word document.
- ☐ **A photo** — a picture of the interviewee, or a relevant historical photo. This becomes the thumbnail people see in listings. Optional but nice to have.
- ☐ **The basic facts** — who was interviewed, who did the interviewing, when it was recorded, and a short summary of what it's about.
- ☐ **Permission to publish** — confirm that the archive may publish the recording, transcript, and photograph according to its release and rights policies.

Step 1: Log in

1. Go to the site's admin address — for example, <https://staging.arlingtonstories.com/admin>.
2. Enter your username (email) and password.

If you don't have a login yet, ask the site administrator to create one for you.

The **admin** side (/admin) is the behind-the-scenes area where you add and edit content. The **public** side (the regular website) is what visitors see. You'll do your work in admin, then check your results on the public site.

Step 2: Start a new interview

1. In the left-hand menu, click **Items**.
2. Click the green **Add new item** button (top right).
3. Before filling anything in, look for the **Resource template** dropdown near the top and choose **"Oral History Interview."**

This last step is important. Choosing the template sets up all the right fields (Interviewee Name, Summary, Transcript, and so on) in the correct order. If the form looks bare or the field names don't match this guide, double-check that the template is selected.

For a tour of the full item form, see [Items: Add an item](#) in the Omeka S manual.

Step 3: Fill in the details

The form is organized into fields. A few are **required** and the rest are optional but make the entry richer.

The essentials (required)

Field	What to put here
Interviewee Name	The person who was interviewed (e.g. <i>Mary Margaret Whipple</i>). This becomes the title of the item.
Summary	A paragraph describing who this person is and what the interview covers. This appears prominently at the top of the item page.
Date Recorded	When the interview was recorded. Prefer the unambiguous YYYY-MM-DD format, such as 2009-03-15.

Recommended extras (optional, but worth adding)

Field	What to put here
Lede	A short one- or two-sentence teaser. This is what shows up in browse listings and search results.
Topics	Keywords or themes covered (e.g. <i>schools, redevelopment, civic life</i>). Add as many as you like.
Interviewer	Who conducted the interview. Enter the name in the archive's standard form, such as Interviewer Name, Last, First Middle.
Neighborhood	The Arlington neighborhood the interview relates to (e.g. <i>Shirlington</i>).
Series Title	The project or series this belongs to (e.g. <i>Project Shirlington</i>).
Duration	How long the recording runs (e.g. <i>1:12:30</i>).

Field	What to put here
Life Dates	The interviewee's birth/death years, if known and appropriate to share.
Interview Location	Where the interview took place.

The transcript

Field	What to put here
Transcript	Paste the full text of the interview here.
Transcript Status	Mark how finished it is: <i>draft</i> , <i>reviewed</i> , or <i>final</i> .
Transcriber	Who typed up the transcript (a person or a service).

Make the transcript interactive: If your transcript includes timestamps in the format [HH:MM:SS] (for example [00:14:30]), the website automatically turns them into clickable links. A visitor can click a timestamp and the audio jumps right to that moment and the transcript highlights along as the recording plays. It's worth adding these if you can; they make the interview much easier to explore.

Use one timestamp at the start of each passage or speaker turn, for example:

[00:00:00] Interviewer: Please introduce yourself.

[00:00:08] Dorothy Henderson: My family has lived in Arlington...

Keep timestamps in square brackets and always include two digits each for hours, minutes, and seconds. Do not add styling or links yourself; the theme does that on the public page.

Step 4: Add the recording and photo

The fields above are the *information about* the interview. Now add the actual files.

1. Select the **Media** tab on the item form.
2. Choose **Upload**, then select your audio or video file.
3. Upload the photo as another media item.
4. After the files appear in the media list, select the photo as the **primary media**. This makes it the thumbnail used on browse pages.

A few notes:

- **Audio and video both work.** .mp3, .m4a, and .mp4 files all play in the built-in player on the interview page.
- **Omeka generates the thumbnail sizes.** You don't need to make separate small copies, but begin with a clear, good-quality image and avoid unnecessary blank space around the subject.
- **The first image is used as the portrait** on the interview page. If you upload several images, order the intended portrait before the others.
- You can upload more than one file (for example, an audio recording *and* a photo).

See the Omeka manual for more on [uploading](#), [reordering](#), and [selecting primary media](#).

Step 5: Put it in a collection and on the site

Two settings control where the interview shows up.

1. **Assign it to a collection.** Select the **Item sets** tab and add this interview to the relevant collection (e.g. *Project Shirlington*). Collections are how interviews are grouped on the public site. An interview may belong to more than one. See [Managing Collections](#) for the full collection workflow.
2. **Assign it to the site.** Select the **Sites** tab and add **Arlington Stories**. An interview that isn't assigned to the site won't appear in public browse or search results, even if everything else is filled in.

Omeka's item documentation explains both the **Item sets** and **Sites** tabs.

Step 6: Make it public and save

1. Find the **visibility** setting (usually a **Public** / **Private** toggle near the top of the form).
 - **Private** = only logged-in staff can see it. Good while you're still working on it.
 - **Public** = anyone visiting the website can see it.
2. When you're ready for the world to see it, set it to **Public**.
3. Click **Save**.

That's it! The interview is now part of the archive.

Omeka also allows individual metadata values to be private. Check the eye icon beside each value if a field unexpectedly remains hidden on the public page.

Step 7: Check your work

Always take a look at the finished page on the public site:

1. Open the public website (e.g. <https://staging.arlingtonstories.com>).
2. Go to **Interviews** and find the one you just added.
3. Check that:
 - The audio or video plays.
 - The summary and details read the way you want.
 - The photo appears.
 - If you added timestamps, clicking one jumps the audio to that spot.

If something looks off, go back into admin, open the item, fix it, and save again. Changes appear right away when you refresh the public page.

The finished interview page combines the portrait, summary, collection, descriptive fields, topic tags, and an automatically generated citation:

A project of the Arlington Historical Society

Visit AHS Donate

ARLINGTON
— STORIES —

Browse

Home > Browse > The Civil War & Freedman's Village > Dorothy Henderson



THE CIVIL WAR & FREEDMAN'S VILLAGE

Dorothy Henderson

1920-2015 · South Arlington

A descendant of Freedman's Village residents traces her family's story from the Civil War contraband camps to modern-day Arlington.

RECORDED

June 14, 2008

DURATION

1:42:18

NEIGHBORHOOD

South Arlington

INTERVIEWER

Interviewed by Margaret Chen

STORY

The Civil War & Freedman's Village

TOPICS

Freedman's Village

Arlington Cemetery

Genealogy

CITE THIS INTERVIEW

Chicago MI A ADA

Putting an interview on the Map

If the **Mapping module** is active, the site can show where interviews are connected to places around Arlington. To map an interview:

1. Open the item in admin (**Items** → **click the interview** → **Edit**).
2. Select the **Mapping** tab on the form.
3. Search for the place or use the marker tool to place a point at the relevant location.
4. Save.

The interview will then appear as a pin on the Map page.

A few good habits

- **Be consistent with Topics, Neighborhoods, and Series Titles.** Reuse established wording instead of creating near-duplicates such as World War II and WWII.
- **Use Private while drafting.** Set an interview to Public only once it's ready, so half-finished entries don't show up for visitors. You can still review private posts on the website if you're

logged into Omeka.

- **You can always come back.** Nothing is set in stone, you can edit any interview later to add a transcript, fix a typo, or swap a photo.
- **One interview = one item.** Each person's interview is its own entry. If someone was interviewed more than once, you can make a separate item for each session.

Troubleshooting

The interview does not appear on the public site

Confirm that the item is **Public** and that **Arlington Stories** appears on its **Sites** tab. Site assignment controls whether an item is included in public browse and search results.

The wrong thumbnail appears

Edit the item, open **Media**, and make the portrait the **primary media**. If there is no usable uploaded image, select a custom thumbnail from the **Advanced** tab.

The collection name or link is missing

Add the collection on the item's **Item sets** tab. If the collection itself is absent from the public Collections page, follow [Show the collection on the site](#).

Timestamps are not clickable

Check that a playable audio or video file is attached and that timestamps use exactly [HH:MM:SS], including brackets and leading zeroes. For example, use [00:07:05], not 7:05.

Quick reference: the publishing checklist

Before setting an interview to Public, confirm:

- ☐ Resource template is "Oral History Interview"
- ☐ **Interviewee Name**, **Summary**, and **Date Recorded** are filled in
- ☐ Audio/video file uploaded and playing
- ☐ Photo added (if available)
- ☐ **Lede** written (the teaser for listings)
- ☐ **Topics** added
- ☐ Assigned to a **collection** (item set)
- ☐ Assigned to the **Arlington Stories site**
- ☐ Visibility set to **Public**
- ☐ Checked the finished page on the public site

Related documentation

- [Managing Collections \(Item Sets\)](#)
- [Omeka S: Items](#)
- [Omeka S: Media](#)
- [Omeka S: Item Sets](#)
- [Omeka S: Mapping](#)

- Project setup and developer notes

Managing Collections (Item Sets)

This guide is for the people who manage the archive. It covers creating a **collection** — a group of interviews on a shared subject or story — giving it a picture and description, and making it show up on the website.

A note on words. On the public site these are called **Stories** or **Collections**. Behind the scenes in the admin, Omeka calls them **Item sets**. They're the same thing: a collection is an item set, and the interviews inside it are items. This guide says "collection" for the idea and "item set" when you're clicking the actual admin menu.

For a full description of the Omeka interface and permissions, see the official [Item Sets documentation](#).

Before you start

Have these ready:

- ☐ **A name** for the collection (e.g. "Project Shirlington").
- ☐ **A short description** — one or two sentences.
- ☐ **A picture** (optional). A collection can borrow a photo from one of its interviews automatically, but you can also give it its own image.
- ☐ **The interviews** you want to include should already exist as items (see [Adding an Oral History](#)). You can also add interviews to the collection later.

Step 1: Create the collection

1. In the left-hand admin menu, under **Resources**, click **Item sets**.
2. Click the green **Add new item set** button (top right).

Step 2: Fill in the details

On the **Values** tab you'll see fields for the collection. Fill in these three:

- **Title** — the collection's name. Shows everywhere the collection appears.
- **Description** — a short teaser. This is the text shown on the **collection cards** (the homepage "Explore by theme" section and the Collections page).
- **Abstract** — a short summary shown on the collection's **own landing page**, next to its picture.

If a field isn't already showing, add it from the property list on the right: open the **Dublin Core** group, then click **Description** or **Abstract** to add it to the form. Type your text in the box that appears.

Description vs. Abstract — why both? The **description** is the teaser on cards; the **abstract** is

the intro on the collection's landing page. They can say similar things. If you only fill in one, fill in the **description** — the cards are the more visible spot.

Step 3: Give it a picture (optional)

1. Click the **Advanced** tab (next to "Values", near the top).
2. Next to **Thumbnail**, click **Select**.
3. Upload a new image, or pick one you've used before, then choose it.

You can skip this. If you don't set a picture, the site automatically borrows the photo from the first interview in the collection that has one. Set a thumbnail here only when you want a specific image instead.

Step 4: Make it public and save

1. Near the top right, check the **visibility** control (the eye icon). It should be set to **Public** so visitors can see the collection.
2. Click the green **Save** button.

Step 5: Add interviews to the collection

Interviews are added to a collection from the **interview's** own page, not here:

1. Go to **Items**, open an interview, and click **Edit**.
2. Find the **Item sets** section and choose this collection.
3. **Save**.

(This is also covered as a step in [Adding an Oral History](#).) You can add as many interviews to a collection as you like, and an interview can belong to more than one collection.

Step 6: Show the collection on the site

This is the step people forget. Creating a collection does *not* automatically put it on the website — you have to add it to the site.

1. In the left menu, click **Sites**, then open **Arlington Voices** (click the pencil / edit icon).
2. In the site's menu, click **Resources**.
3. Click the **Item sets** tab.
4. In the panel on the right, click your collection to add it to the list.
5. Click **Save**.

If a collection is missing from the site, this is almost always why: it was created but never added under **Resources** → **Item sets**. It's done from the **site** side, not from the collection's own edit page.

See [Site Resources: Item Sets](#) in the Omeka manual for screenshots of this interface.

Where your collection appears

Once it's public and added to the site, the collection shows up in three places:

- **Homepage** — the newest collections appear in the "Explore by theme" section (with the picture and description).
 - **Collections page** — the full grid of collections.
 - **Its own landing page** — the picture and abstract at the top, with the list of interviews below.
-

Quick reference: the checklist

- ☐ **Item sets** → **Add new item set**
- ☐ Fill in **Title**, **Description**, and **Abstract**
- ☐ (Optional) **Advanced** → **Thumbnail** → choose a picture
- ☐ Set to **Public** and **Save**
- ☐ Add interviews (from each interview's **Edit** page → **Item sets**)
- ☐ **Sites** → **Arlington Voices** → **Resources** → **Item sets** → add the collection → **Save**
- ☐ Check it on the public site

Building and Editing Site Pages

This guide is for staff and volunteers creating interpretive pages in Arlington Stories—for example, an About page, a historical essay, a project introduction, or a small online exhibit.

You do **not** need an additional module to create a page with formatted text, images, audiovisual material, links, and multi-column layouts. Omeka S provides these features through page **blocks**. The official [Site Pages](#) manual includes screenshots of the interface and every native block.

How pages and blocks work

A site page is assembled from individual blocks, each responsible for one kind of content. Blocks can be added, configured, reordered, grouped, and removed without editing a theme template.

The most useful blocks for this project are:

Block	Use it for
HTML	Formatted text, headings, lists, quotations, and links.
Asset	A standalone image used on a page, such as a photograph, logo, diagram, or map.
Media embed	Image, audio, video, or other media already attached to an Omeka item.
Browse preview	A live list or grid of items, item sets, or media selected by a query.
List of pages	A hand-selected list of links to other pages in the same site.
Table of contents	Navigation for child pages beneath the current page.
oEmbed	Content hosted by a supported service such as YouTube, Vimeo, or SoundCloud.
Line break	Spacing or a visual break between sections.
Map by query / attachments / groups	Interactive maps when the Mapping module is active.

Modules may add more blocks, but start with the native choices above. Fewer block types make a page easier to maintain.

Step 1: Create a page

1. Log in to Omeka and select **Sites**.
2. Edit **Arlington Stories** using its pencil icon.
3. Select **Pages** in the site administration menu.
4. Click **Add new page**.
5. Enter a clear **Title**.
6. Optionally edit the **URL slug**. Use lowercase words separated by hyphens, such as freedmans-village-history.
7. Choose whether to **Add to navigation**. Leave this unchecked if the page should be a child page or if you want to position it manually later.
8. Use the eye icon to choose **Public** or **Private**. Private is best while drafting.
9. Click **Add** to open the page editor.

The theme already displays the page's title in a large header. Do not add a separate **Page title** block unless you intentionally want the title repeated in the page content.

Step 2: Choose a layout mode

Omeka provides two native layout modes:

- **Normal flow** stacks blocks in reading order and lets text wrap around aligned media. Use this for most essays and informational pages.
- **Grid** divides a page into columns. Each block receives a position and a span (width). Use it only when the page genuinely needs side-by-side sections or a deliberate multi-column composition.

Start with **Normal flow**. It is easier to edit and produces the most predictable results on phones and tablets. If you use Grid, preview the page at both wide and narrow browser widths before publishing.

Step 3: Add and format text

1. Select **HTML** from the block list on the right.
2. Click inside the editing area to reveal the formatting toolbar.
3. Enter or paste the page text.
4. Use the toolbar for paragraph styles, headings, bold, italics, lists, quotations, and links.
5. Use meaningful heading levels in order: start page sections with Heading 2, then use Heading 3 for subsections. Do not use headings merely to make text look larger.
6. Apply changes, then save the page.

When pasting from Word or Google Docs, check the result for unexpected fonts, spacing, or colors. If necessary, paste as plain text and reapply simple formatting in Omeka.

The **Source** button permits raw HTML, but most editors should avoid it. Embedded code can break

responsive layouts or introduce inaccessible content. Use a purpose-built block whenever one exists.

Step 4: Add an image

Choose the block based on what the image represents:

- Use **Asset** for an image that belongs to the page itself and is not part of an archival item.
- Use **Media embed** when the image or audiovisual file is already attached to an Omeka item and should remain connected to that record.

For a typical editorial image with wrapping text:

1. Add the **Asset** or **Media embed** block **before** the related HTML block.
2. Select or upload the image. Media embed selections come from media already attached to items.
3. Add a concise caption and credit when appropriate.
4. For Media embed, choose a suitable image type such as **medium** or **large**.
5. Apply the block changes and save the page.
6. View the public page and confirm the image, caption, and surrounding text read correctly.

Image sizing in this theme

Arlington Stories deliberately standardizes editorial Asset and Media blocks:

- on wider screens, an image floats to the right at approximately 340 pixels wide, never exceeding 42% of the text column;
- text in the following HTML block wraps around it; and
- below 700 pixels, the image stacks at full width above the text.

This behavior is defined in `theme/asset/css/page-blocks.css`. Editors normally should not resize images with inline HTML or fixed pixel dimensions.

For a special layout, first try Omeka's **Grid** mode and block span settings on a private test page. Because the theme applies its own editorial image treatment, check the public result carefully. If the design needs a full-width hero, unusually small image, or a repeatable custom pattern, ask the theme maintainer to add a named style instead of pasting one-off CSS into the page.

Step 5: Add archival or dynamic content

Show an item or recording

Use **Media embed** to select a specific image, audio recording, or video attached to an item. Use **Item with metadata** when the page should show the item's descriptive record as well as its media.

Show a changing list of resources

Use **Browse preview** to display items, item sets, or media matching a query. This is better than manually maintaining links when the list should update as new resources are added.

Link a set of related pages

Use **List of pages** for a curated list. Use **Table of contents** when the pages are arranged as children of the current page in **Site** → **Navigation**.

Add a map

When Mapping is active, use **Map by query** for a map generated from matching items or **Map by attachments** for hand-selected resources. See the [Mapping documentation](#) for block options.

Step 6: Reorder and group blocks

- Drag a block by its handle to move it earlier or later in the reading order.
- Use the gear icon to open layout settings for an individual block.
- Use **Add block group** to keep related blocks together and apply shared spacing, background, or alignment.
- In Normal flow, place an image or media block before the HTML block whose text should wrap around it.
- Remember that deleting a block group also deletes the blocks inside it.

The visual order should also be the logical reading order. Do not rely on columns to make unrelated source-order content appear connected.

Step 7: Save, preview, and publish

1. Save the page frequently.
2. Use **View** to open the public page.
3. Check headings, links, captions, and reading order.
4. Resize the browser or inspect the page on a phone to check wrapping and stacking.
5. Confirm that images are clear and audiovisual material plays.
6. Add or arrange the page under **Site** → **Navigation** if visitors need it in the menu.
7. Change the page from Private to Public when review is complete.

Changes do not appear publicly until the page is saved.

Special case: editing the homepage

The Arlington Stories homepage is partly controlled by the theme. Page blocks entered on the homepage are displayed in an editorial area, but the hero, recently added interviews, and “Explore by Stories” sections are generated automatically by the theme.

Use homepage blocks for introductory or supporting editorial content. Do not try to recreate the theme-generated sections with duplicate blocks. Site-wide hero text and other configurable labels are managed under **Site** → **Theme** → **Theme settings** and in the site's Summary field.

Do we need Block Plus?

Recommendation: no, not for ordinary pages. Omeka S 4.2 already includes formatted HTML, Asset and Media blocks, block groups, Normal flow, and Grid layouts. Those native tools satisfy the requirement for basic pages with text, media, formatting, and image placement.

Block Plus version 3.4.45 and its required **Common** dependency are already bundled in this repository, so they can be activated later without adding another ZIP. **Block Plus** becomes useful when the archive has a specific need for:

- reusable page models or preconfigured groups of blocks;
- the supplied **Simple page**, **Exhibit**, or **Exhibit page** models;
- a repeatable “Resource with text” group;
- advanced blocks such as mirror pages, galleries, showcases, graphs, or enhanced search forms;
- or
- a consistent multi-page exhibit workflow that has been tested with the theme.

It also introduces more interface choices, dependencies, and theme-testing work. Several of its older features now overlap with capabilities added to Omeka core in version 4.1 and later. Leave it inactive unless a defined page pattern needs it.

Safely evaluate **Block Plus**

1. Work in the local or staging environment.
2. Under **Admin** → **Modules**, install or activate **Common** first, then **Block Plus**.
3. Create a private test page rather than converting a published page.
4. Try the native tools and the relevant **Block Plus** page model side by side.
5. Test the public result on desktop and mobile.
6. Adopt the module only if the model saves meaningful editorial work and produces a stable result in this theme.

See [Managing Omeka S Modules](#) for activation and deployment details.

Troubleshooting

The page exists but visitors cannot find it

Confirm that the page is Public and has been added under **Site** → **Navigation**. A public page can exist without appearing in the menu.

Text does not wrap around an image

In Normal flow, move the Asset or Media block before the related HTML block. Save and refresh the public page.

The image is the wrong size

First verify that the public page is using this theme and that the image is in an Asset or Media block. Try the intended thumbnail size for Media embed. For exceptional layouts, test Grid mode or request a reusable theme style; avoid hard-coded inline dimensions.

A block is unavailable

Native blocks should always be present. Map blocks require Mapping to be active; **Block Plus** blocks require **Common** and **Block Plus** to be installed and active. Check **Admin** → **Modules** or ask a Global Administrator.

The homepage does not match the block order

The homepage uses a custom theme layout. Its automatic hero, recent interviews, and story cards are not represented by page blocks in the editor.

Publishing checklist

- ☐ Page has a clear title and readable URL slug
- ☐ Drafted as Private until reviewed
- ☐ Headings follow a logical order
- ☐ Links work and use descriptive text
- ☐ Images have appropriate captions, credits, and alternative text where available
- ☐ Asset and Media blocks are used consistently
- ☐ Page checked at desktop and mobile widths
- ☐ Page added to navigation if visitors should find it there
- ☐ Visibility set to Public when approved

Related documentation

- [Managing Omeka S Modules](#)
- [Adding an Oral History](#)
- [Managing Collections](#)
- [Omeka S: Site Pages](#)
- [Omeka S: Mapping](#)
- [Block Plus](#)

Managing Omeka S Modules

This guide explains what modules are, which modules are bundled with Arlington Stories, and how a repository maintainer and an Omeka administrator work together to add one.

For the standard Omeka interface, see the official [Modules Management](#) guide, which includes screenshots.

The short version

Modules cannot be uploaded through the Omeka admin interface. In this project:

1. A repository maintainer downloads a compatible release ZIP and places it in `plugins/`.
2. The project's Docker startup script extracts new module ZIPs into Omeka.
3. A Global Administrator opens **Admin** → **Modules** and installs or activates the module.

If you are an archive editor and need a module that is not listed under **Modules**, send the module name and its download page to the repository maintainer. Do not download an arbitrary ZIP or source-code snapshot yourself.

Three module states

It helps to distinguish three similar-sounding states:

- **Bundled** means a release ZIP is stored in this repository's `plugins/` directory. It will be available whenever the project is deployed from the repository.
- **Installed** means Omeka has registered the module and run any database setup it requires.
- **Active** means the installed module's features are currently enabled.

The **Admin** → **Modules** page is the authoritative place to check whether a bundled module is installed and active. A ZIP in the repository does not prove that the module has been activated on every deployment.

Activate a module that is already bundled

Only a Global Administrator can install, activate, deactivate, or configure modules. Other account roles may have less access.

1. Log in to the Omeka admin dashboard.
2. Select **Modules** in the left navigation.
3. Find the module by name.
4. Follow the action shown beside it:
 - **Install** registers the module and normally activates it automatically.
 - **Activate** enables a module that is installed but inactive.
 - **Configure** opens settings for a module that provides them.
5. Confirm that Omeka displays a success message.
6. Test the relevant admin feature and its public display.

If Omeka reports a missing dependency, install or activate the dependency first. For example, **Block Plus** requires **Common**.

Deactivate is not the same as uninstall. Deactivation turns features off while preserving the module's data. Uninstalling may delete module-created database tables and data. Do not uninstall a module without a backup and a specific removal plan.

Add a new module to the project

These steps require repository and deployment access and are intended for a maintainer.

1. Find and evaluate the module

Start with the official [Omeka S Modules directory](#). Before downloading anything, confirm:

- the release supports **Omeka S 4.2** (the version used by this project);
- it comes from the module's official download or releases page;
- all required dependencies are available;
- its maintenance status, documentation, license, and support channel are acceptable; and
- its feature does not duplicate something already provided by Omeka core or a bundled module.

Download a packaged **release ZIP**, not a repository's “source code” archive. Release packages may contain dependencies that are absent from source snapshots.

2. Add the ZIP to `plugins/`

Keep the module name and version in the filename, following the existing convention:

```
plugins/ModuleName-1.2.3.zip
```

The ZIP should expand to one top-level module directory whose name does not include a version number—for example, `Mapping/`, not `Mapping-2.2.0/`.

3. Restart the Omeka service

From the repository root:

```
docker compose restart omeka-s
```

The `plugins/` directory is mounted inside the container at `/srv/plugins`. On startup, `docker/omeka-s/install-modules.sh` extracts any new ZIP whose module directory is not already present.

To verify what happened:

```
docker compose logs omeka-s
```

Look for `Installing module: ModuleName` or `Module already installed: ModuleName`.

4. Install or activate it in Omeka

The repository step makes the module available; it does not complete Omeka's database installation. A Global Administrator must finish the process under **Admin** → **Modules**.

5. Test before publishing

Test the module in the local or staging environment before deploying it to production. At minimum, verify:

- installation and activation complete without errors;
- existing admin and public pages still load;
- the new feature works with this theme;
- pages remain usable at desktop and mobile widths; and
- deactivation returns the site to a working state.

Commit the release ZIP and any required theme integration together so future deployments remain reproducible.

Updating an existing module

Adding a new module and upgrading an existing one are different operations. The startup script deliberately does **not** overwrite an existing module directory, so replacing a ZIP with a newer version and restarting is not sufficient.

Plan upgrades with a maintainer. Back up the database and current module, check the module's upgrade instructions, replace the deployed module directory safely, and then use the **Upgrade** action under **Admin** → **Modules**. Never use `docker compose down -v` as an upgrade method: it deletes the project database and other persistent volumes.

See Omeka's [Updating a module](#) instructions for the general process.

Worked example: how Mapping was added

Mapping is the module that adds locations to items and interactive maps to sites.

For this project:

1. The official Mapping-2.2.0.zip release was added to `plugins/`.
2. Docker mounts that directory at `/srv/plugins` in the Omeka container.
3. The startup script extracts the ZIP as `/var/www/html/modules/Mapping` when the module is not already present.
4. A Global Administrator installs or activates **Mapping** under **Admin** → **Modules**.
5. Mapping adds a **Mapping** tab to the item editor, map page blocks, and a **Map Browse** navigation option.
6. The theme's `mapping/site/index/browse.phtml` override gives the public Map Browse page the Arlington Stories presentation while preserving Mapping's scripts and styles.

Editors can then add locations from an item's **Mapping** tab. See [Putting an interview on the map](#) for the content workflow.

Modules currently bundled

The following release ZIPs are currently stored in `plugins/`. Their installation and activation state may differ by deployment.

Module	Version	What it provides
Activity Log	1.0.1	Records user activity for administrative review.
Advanced Search	3.4.61	Adds richer search fields, filters, facets, and search pages.
Block Plus	3.4.45	Adds page models and advanced editorial blocks; requires Common.
Bulk Edit	3.4.39	Adds advanced batch metadata cleanup and editing tools.
Clean URL	3.17.14	Provides configurable, human-readable resource URLs.
Common	3.4.86	Supplies shared infrastructure required by several other modules.
Custom Vocab	2.1.0	Lets administrators create controlled lists of metadata values.
Faceted Browse	1.9.2	Adds filterable, faceted browsing pages.
Feed	3.4.9	Produces RSS and Atom feeds for selected pages or resources.
Google Analytics	1.3.1	Adds Google Analytics tracking when configured.
Mapping	2.2.0	Adds item locations, interactive maps, map blocks, and map browsing.
Metadata Browse	1.6.1	Links metadata values to resources sharing the same value.
Resource Meta	1.1.0	Adds configurable metadata tags to public resource pages.
Rights Statements	1.2.1	Adds RightsStatements.org choices for rights metadata.
Sharing	1.5.0	Adds tools for sharing and embedding public content.
Sitemaps	1.1	Generates site-specific XML sitemaps for search engines.
Statistics	3.4.14	Adds administrative counts and statistics about resources.
Universal Viewer	3.6.15-4.2.1	Provides a unified viewer for images, PDFs, audiovisual files, and IIIF content.

Troubleshooting

The module does not appear under Admin → Modules

- Confirm that its ZIP exists in `plugins/`.
- Confirm that the Omeka container restarted after the ZIP was added.
- Check `docker compose logs omeka-s` for extraction errors.
- Inspect the ZIP structure: it must contain one correctly named module directory, not an extra wrapper directory.
- Confirm that the module supports Omeka S 4.2 and the server's PHP version.

Omeka reports a missing dependency

Locate the dependency in `plugins/`, install or activate it first, then retry the original module. Consult the module's release documentation for version requirements.

A module is present but its feature is missing

Check whether the module is merely installed but inactive. Some modules also require configuration, a site setting, a navigation entry, or a particular page block before anything appears publicly.

Related documentation

- Building and Editing Site Pages
- Adding an Oral History
- Omeka S: Modules Management
- Omeka S Modules directory
- Omeka S: Mapping
- Developer notes